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The Instruments

Except for the piano, the evolution of the jazz instruments is part of that of the jazz orchestral styles. It may be broadly summed up as follows: The clarinet reached its peak of development in New Orleans jazz, and has since then dropped progressively into the background. The brass reached its peak of development in the ‘swing’ era, and has since then also lost ground. The saxes follow an ascending curve from the early 1920s until the ‘bop’ period, when they reach their peak, but have remained stationary since. The percussive instruments follow a steadily ascending curve until the cool period, when they become, in some instances, the major carriers of melody as well as of rhythm (e.g. Modern Jazz Quartet: piano, vibes, drums, bass). In spite of repeated attempts, nobody has yet managed to do more with bowed string instruments than use them for occasional effects. If they have a future in jazz, it is still to come. There are signs, as in the use of a cello by Oscar Pettiford or of the bowed bass by various artists, that players are today making efforts to conquer even these highly recalcitrant instruments for jazz. Within this general framework, however, there is infinite variety. Jazz is what individual players make it, and each player has his individual voice. Attempts have been made to trace the evolution and cross-fertilizations of instrumental styles in diagrammatic form,¹ but even the most lucid diagram looks rather like a wiring plan for a complex electrical installation. I do not propose to give a detailed account of these instrumental marches and counter-marches here, but merely to list a few of the major players and influences.

The two clarinet styles of New Orleans—the liquid ‘creole’ and the dirty ‘blues’ clarinet—reach their respective peaks early in the triumvirate of Jimmy Noone (1895–1944), Johnny Dodds (1892–1940), and Sidney Bechet (1897–1959), who is better known for his adaptation

of the clarinet to the otherwise scarcely used soprano sax. The reserve team of Bigard (born 1906), Nicholas (born 1900), Hall (born 1901), and Simeon (1902–1959) is somewhat less powerful. All these musicians come from New Orleans. Among white players the Chicagoans Teschemacher (1906–32) and ‘Pee-Wee’ Russell (born 1906) developed the ‘dirty’ style, while Benny Goodman (born 1909) is technically perhaps the most brilliant player of the instrument, white or black.² It is doubtful whether, if all records later than 1930 were destroyed—except for those of Bechet, who was poorly recorded in those days—our picture of the technical and emotional possibilities of this instrument as hitherto used in jazz would be incomplete. Dodd’s marvellous playing with Louis Armstrong and with his own New Orleans Wanderers, Simeon’s contributions on the Jelly-Roll Morton records, and Bigard’s with Morton and Ellington demonstrate the range of the instrument.

The cornet, and from the later 1920s its successor the trumpet, is hereditary king of jazz, though for a time it was in semi-exile under the moderns. There are therefore more brilliant trumpeters than stars of any other instrument in jazz history. However, all discussion of the jazz trumpet must begin and end with Louis Armstrong (born 1900) the greatest jazzman of them all, in whose art New Orleans music culminates and is surpassed.³ Louis Armstrong is not just a trumpeter: he is the voice of his people speaking on a horn. A natural genius, who intuitively organizes his art with the automatic assurance with which the bodies of lesser men manage their breathing, he has been exceptionally lucky. Born twenty years earlier, he would have been a splendid folk-trumpeter, a leader of a street band, lacking both the technical equipment and the capacity to speak with a fully individual voice. Born fifteen years later, or anywhere but in New Orleans, he would have lacked those firm roots in the folk-music of his city which allow the tree of his genius to grow steadily. For Armstrong is not made to find his way through the eclectic jungle of middle period jazz or the intellectual mazes of the moderns: he is a simple man; in terms of verbal intelligence even an inarticulate one. But he was born just at the time when he could pass logically from the folk-jazz of New Orleans to complete individualism in art, without losing either his bearings or the wonderful, simple, singing quality, the common

touch, of a music made for ordinary people. There is nothing more to be said about Armstrong, except that he has the rare gift of complete innocence, which, because it reads the genuine emotions of men into the phoney formulae of pop songs, can make even these moving and totally convincing. Armstrong's evolution out of New Orleans jazz can be followed in his records with King Oliver, in the marvellous Hot Fives and Hot Sevens of 1925–7, and in the astonishing freedom of the Hot Sevens of 1928–30, when he played a music untrammelled by any formal traditions in the company of players who could hold a candle to him: in the *West End Blues* or *Potato Head Blues*, one of which would probably win in a poll for the best single jazz record ever made, in *Tight Like This*, *Muggles*, *Mahogany Hall Stomp*, and the rest. After this, though Armstrong's powers improved, he rarely played in ensembles worthy of him, except sometimes after 1940, when he was, however, somewhat confined by the purist tastes of the 'revivalist' public which has been his main support. His solos in the thirties and even in the late fifties are sometimes even better than they were, but the originality and perfection of the records as a whole are less. There is plenty of argument about him, but if one thing is certain in the world of jazz, it is that every critic worth his name would, were he asked to name a single person who personifies jazz, vote for him.

Good trumpeters are so numerous that it is hardly possible to mention more than a few who were in some sense innovators, though perhaps Tommy Ladnier (1900–39), a technically limited player, and Joe Smith (1902–37) ought not to be left out, for the perfection with which they played the classic blues, Frankie Newton (1906–54), and Buck Clayton (born 1911) because this writer is fond of them, and Cootie Williams (born 1908) for Ellington's *Concerto for Cootie*. Bubber Miley (1902–32) pioneered the systematic use of the mute and the 'growl'. Red Allen (born 1908) and the more important Roy Eldridge (born 1911) developed the more brilliant trumpet style of the 'swing' era. Charlie Shavers (born 1917) approaches modernism, which emerges fully fledged in Dizzy Gillespie (born 1917), technically the most brilliant and revolutionary trumpeter of the modern era. Miles Davis (born 1926) is pre-eminently the player who represents the cool style, though the death of Fats Navarro

(1923–50) almost certainly deprived us of a modern trumpeter to hold his own with both.⁴

Among white players only one can be named in this company, Leon Bismarck ('Bix') Beiderbecke (1903–31), who is pretty generally admitted to be the finest white jazz musician up to the present.⁵ Bix's evolution out of a modified Dixieland style was cut short, but his astonishing combination of melodious sweetness, drive, a spontaneous sophisticated jazz sense and a constant, veiled melancholy even in his most joyous solos, can still move us. The other white players are good journeymen, except perhaps for Bunny Berigan (1909–42), a lesser Bix, Bobby Hackett (born 1915), a lesser swing player, and Max Kaminsky of Chicago (born 1908). Not that in jazz 'journeyman' is a dishonourable title. Men like Muggsy Spanier (born 1906), who has played honest and moving Dixieland cornet, have no cause to regret their careers.

The trombone had barely glimpsed its full instrumental possibilities in New Orleans jazz, though it could, with Charlie 'Big' Green (1900–36), play the blues, and was always essential to the polyphony. Jimmy Harrison (1900–31) in the 1920s virtually made it into a solo instrument in the full sense, much as Armstrong emancipated the trumpet from the limitations of the New Orleans ensemble. Ellington's 'Tricky Sam' Nanton (1904–48) developed its possibilities with the growl mute. Dickie Wells (born 1909), perhaps with Johnson the best trombonist in jazz history, the lesser J. C. Higginbotham (born 1906), and Vic Dickenson (born 1906) adapted the instrument to the swing era and brought it to its highest pitch of achievement. J. J. Johnson (born 1924) is the trombonist of the modern style, though perhaps his chief innovation is the technically dazzling one of playing the instrument with unprecedented speed and brilliance.

Among the whites, who are a little less outclassed in this field, Miff Mole (born 1898) and Tommy Dorsey (1904–56) developed the technical possibilities of the instrument without exploiting them for jazz purposes, while the Dane, Kai Winding (born 1922), among the moderns, should be mentioned. There are few Red Indians in jazz, but those few seem to have a taste for the trombone: Jack Teagarden (born 1905) leads them,

the best non-black player of the blues on his instrument, though a little lacking in bite.⁶

The saxophone entered jazz late. The years when journalists identified jazz by its ‘wailing saxophones’ were precisely those when the few jazz saxophonists had barely emancipated themselves from the New Orleans clarinet tradition. However, from the middle twenties a number of brilliant and sensitive instrumentalists developed a technique for it and made its remarkable flexibility fully available to jazz. In the swing, and especially the early modern period, the saxes really did become the central instrument of jazz, almost displacing the clarinet and pushing even the brass into the background. This is no doubt because they lend themselves to musically justified technical virtuosity: they are the string-section of jazz. The natural styles of trumpet and trombone are sober. These are strong and rigid rather than nimble instruments. The technical fireworks of the modernists have not added anything substantial to their possibilities, but have merely shown that they can be played faster and with a smoother tone, and hit higher notes than before, or that they can be made to sound like other instruments. However, the saxes did have unexploited possibilities. Their sound ranges from the reediest and dirtiest vibrato to a flute-like smoothness, and they combine a flexibility admirably suited to jazz expressiveness with a force and drive which can make them the main propellents of smaller bands. It is perhaps true that their natural style is one of romantic rhapsody or baroque floweriness, such as was developed by the pioneers of the instrument—say Hodges on alto and Hawkins on tenor—or, with a deliberate restriction of the instrument’s musical palette, by the great Charlie Parker. The natural classicists among jazz lovers will always hanker for the simple lines of brass. But if any instrument was jazz between 1930 and 1950 it was the sax.

More specifically, the tenor sax, which has become increasingly popular since Coleman Hawkins (born 1904) made it, virtually single-handed, into a solo instrument in the 1920s. Hawkins, whose supremacy was long unchallenged, and who is still as good a tenor player as any, evolved a powerful but soft sound, making full use of the instrument’s reedy qualities, and a characteristic style of rhapsodic improvisation.

Virtually, all sax players of the earlier generation are his pupils: Chu Berry (1910–41), Herschel Evans (1909–39), Don Byas (born 1912), Ben Webster (born 1909), Lucky Thompson (born 1924), and Illinois Jacquet (born 1921). Meanwhile in Kansas City the other great innovator, Lester Young (1909–59), laid the foundations of the cool style with a smoother, deliberately much less ‘beautiful’ tone and a tendency to play long melodic lines consisting of relatively few notes. (The white musicians Bud Freeman [born 1906] and Frank Trumbauer [1900–57] had actually pioneered this development.) Young’s disciples are numerous: Wardell Gray (1921–55) among blacks, Stan Getz (born 1927), Zoot Sims (born 1925), Al Cohn (born 1925), Gerry Mulligan (born 1927) on baritone among whites.⁷ The great Charlie Parker claimed not to have been influenced by either, which leaves those who like to argue derivations free to argue them at length.

The rest of the sax family has a less coherent history. The soprano, baritone, and bass have never really established themselves. The soprano remains the private voice of Sidney Bechet, one of the glories of New Orleans, the bass a rarely used freak. The baritone was for long the monopoly of Harry Carney (born 1910) of Ellington’s band, but became more popular in the cool period among white players like Serge Chaloff (1923–57) and Gerry Mulligan (born 1927), who plays it as though it were a tenor.

The alto was established in jazz by a trinity of notable musicians: Benny Carter (born 1907), Willie Smith (born 1908), and Johnny Hodges (born 1906) of Ellington’s band, who would, but for the existence of Charlie Parker, be the unquestioned king of this instrument today as in 1929: a marvel of skill, sensitivity, and flexible, but not weak, melodic beauty. ‘Pete’ Brown (born 1906) and Earl Bostic (born 1913) developed it into a swing instrument, with a honking, jumping, sometimes tasteless style much appreciated in Harlem. But it was the accident that Charlie Parker (who also played tenor) preferred this lighter and more individually distinctive horn, which made it, from 1941, compete in influence with the tenor. The whites, Lee Konitz (born 1927) and Art Pepper (born 1925), have developed the Parker tradition, though it is characteristic that among the blacks the most typical Parker disciples,

like Sonny Stitt (born 1924) and Sonny Rollins (born 1929), reverted to the tenor.⁸

Charlie 'Bird' Parker (1920–55), the one unquestioned genius in 'modern' jazz, is more than an alto player.⁹ He was a musical revolutionary, whose ideas dominate virtually everything that has been written in modern jazz since the early forties. He was also a volcanic soul, whose eruptions sent, and send, shivers of awe down the spines of listeners and colleagues. His deliberate revolutionism temporarily obscured his roots in tradition: for what Parker plays is the unadulterated, lowest of low-down blues. He is to jazz in the forties and fifties what Armstrong is to the earlier jazz. But it is typical that this quintessential figure of modern jazz was not only (like Armstrong) a lumpen-proletarian boy—in this instance from Kansas City—but, unlike Armstrong, a twisted, displaced person. A vagabond, a drug-addict, an unhappy, unattached wanderer who died at 35, he is the Rimbaud of modern jazz.

THE RHYTHM INSTRUMENTS

The evolution of the rhythm instruments—again with the exception of the piano, which counts as such in jazz—is first towards subtler rhythmic possibilities, and then towards a sort of fusion between rhythm and melody, such as is wholly new in European music, though there are plenty of African precedents for it. Since rhythm is the heart-beat of jazz, and the essential organizing medium of this music, the importance of these instruments, notably the drums, is obvious. The weakness of all European jazz hitherto has been at bottom the weakness of its rhythm sections. For, while Europe has produced plenty of musicians who can hold their own in any good American band, and plenty more who could do so if they had as much practice as the Americans, it has so far produced only one rhythmicist of stature.^{*} He, characteristically enough, was a gypsy—the guitarist Django Reinhardt (1910–53), and equally characteristically, he is the only European jazzman who has so far found a certain place in the jazz pantheon.

The evolution of rhythm towards a fusion with melody must not be confused with increasing virtuosity, though the two go together; nor with the turn from rhythm to melody. There is a tendency, notably among white players, to separate these things. Thus the Sicilian Eddie Lang (Salvatore Massaro, 1904–33), who developed the solo melodic and harmonic possibilities of the jazz guitar very far indeed, did so at the expense of swing. White drummers have often played with solo rhythm at the expense of the rhythm of the whole band, which is the rhythm-maker's primary responsibility, except perhaps in an instrumental break: the drummer Gene Krupa of Chicago (born 1909) has this tendency.

The lesser rhythm instruments, guitar (banjo) and bass, can be considered together. The bass is played pizzicato in jazz. It provides the harmonic basis for instrumental improvisation, but also—and increasingly—the main, unchanging beat of the music. As Berendt observes, the fact that the bass replaced the tuba, which had first been used in this function, 'tells us more about the spirit of jazz than many theoretical arguments: the plucked strings of the bass are rhythmically more precise and clear than the blown notes of the tuba'.¹⁰ At all events, the classic jazz bass Pops Foster (born 1892) in New Orleans, John Kirby (born 1908), and that rock of Kansas rhythm Walter Page (1900–57), developed the instrument increasingly into a steady pillar of the beat. The melodic development of the bass is, until the middle forties, almost wholly the work of Ellington, who persistently attempted to capture the special tone-colour of the instrument for his orchestral palette (with the help of the recording microphone, which could make it audible through the rest of the band). He drew out Wellman Braud (born 1891), but above all, in 1939 he discovered Jimmy Blanton (1921–42), with whom he played duets. Blanton revolutionized the instrument. He 'improvised as though the bass was a horn, phrasing fluently with frequent eight- and sixteen-note runs, using harmonic and melodic ideas which were unheard of on the instrument.'¹¹ Blanton's successor, Oscar Pettiford (1922–60), was also his disciple, as are all the sophisticated and ambitious modern players, notably Charles Mingus (born 1922), Percy Heath (born 1923), and Ray Brown (born 1926). The banjo (later guitar) had, from the start, two possibilities: to provide rhythmic and harmonic foundations for the

band and—a technique developed by the individual blues singers—to respond to the voice in the blues in single notes and clusters. Johnny St Cyr (banjo, born 1890) provided the perfect solution in the first style for New Orleans jazz, Freddie Greene (born 1911) of Basie's band for the swing period. Their self-abnegation and avoidance of solos should not obscure their tremendous merits. The 'single-note' style was first popularized in bands by the blues player Lonnie Johnson (born 1894), and developed by Teddy Bunn (born 1909), and Al Casey (born 1915), who combine the two approaches, and Django Reinhardt. But once again a single musician revolutionized the instrument at the end of the 1930s: Charlie Christian (1919–42), perhaps the greatest single precursor of bop, in whose early experiments he took part.¹² Christian, a dazzling technician, developed the guitar into a primary melody carrier—admittedly at the price of electric amplification—sophisticated its rhythm and, imitating the tenor sax, which he also played, developed a legato way of playing melodies on it. His harmonic innovations went far beyond the field of his instrument.

The piano in orchestral jazz, belongs, with drums, bass, and guitar, to the rhythm section, but is too powerful an instrument to be confined to it. It is also the genuine solo instrument of jazz, i.e. the one whose performances can stand unaccompanied, though it benefits from rhythm accompaniment. Other unaccompanied instrumental and vocal solos have been recorded in jazz, e.g. by trumpet, various saxophones, and guitar (which can function like a lesser piano), but these are abnormalities. The piano solo is the only one to have established a permanent place in jazz. The history of piano jazz is therefore both different from that of the other jazz instruments and more complex.

Two major pianistic styles stand at the beginning of jazz, one extremely sophisticated, one extremely primitive: 'ragtime' and 'blues piano' or 'boogie-woogie'. Ragtime has already been briefly described in the section on the orchestral styles of jazz. Ragtime style and technique were evolved, on the whole, by musically educated and ambitious players, perhaps the only case of its kind, if we except the evolution of the creole clarinet style. It soon died out, but apart from a wide general influence, it left two important lines of descent. The first was the New

Orleans brothel-piano style, whose finest recorded master is Jelly-Roll Morton (1885–1941). The second, much more influential, is the ‘Eastern’ or ‘Harlem’ style, which has produced the most vigorous pianistic tradition in jazz. Its chief figures, from the New York circle, are James P. Johnson (born 1891), Willie ‘The Lion’ Smith (born 1897), and Fats Waller (1904–43), all of whom are ragtime pianists or very close to it, Duke Ellington (born 1899) and Count Basie (born 1904), less eminent as soloists but more important for their orchestral use of the piano, and—remote modernist descendants—Bud Powell (born 1924) and Thelonius Monk (born 1920). Probably we should also count the extraordinarily fertile ‘Pittsburgh circle’, which has produced such innovating players as the dazzling Earl Hines (born 1905), Mary Lou Williams (born 1910), and among the modernists, Erroll Garner (born 1921), with the ‘Eastern school’, whose remote origins, the experts tell us, go back to the gospel shouts of the Eastern Appalachians. Stylistically the most brilliant virtuoso of the jazz piano, the late Art Tatum (1910–56), belongs to the New York tradition, standing somewhere between Fats Waller and Bud Powell. However, though he also belongs to the North-East, he was born in Toledo, Ohio.^{13†}

All these descendants of ragtime piano are normally characterized by lightness, wit, sophistication, technical virtuosity, and melodiousness. At their best, as in Fats Waller, they produce perhaps the most universally pleasing type of jazz music. These solo piano styles seem to have evolved in two directions. On the one hand, with Earl Hines—one of the most remarkable of a remarkable group of musicians—players attempted the feat of adapting the piano to the vocalizing style of the other instruments (the so-called ‘trumpet style’); Hines’s partnership with Louis Armstrong in 1928–30 produced some of the most satisfactory and impressive jazz on record. On the other hand, players exploited the capacity of the piano for a combination of technical brilliance and original harmonic experiments, which led logically to the modern pianists’ styles. At all times the capacity of the piano to combine rhythm, harmony, and melody has been the foundation of jazz piano playing.

Blues piano¹⁴ (‘barrel-house’, ‘honky-tonk’, ‘boogie-woogie’) is as primitive as ragtime was sophisticated, though it shows ragtime

influences, probably because many barrel-house pianists taught themselves to play the instrument by copying the movement of the keys on automatic player-pianos performing ragtime piano rolls. It seems to have originated in the lowest saloons and dives of the South and South-West, where piano players shouted the blues and beat it out on battered out-of-tune uprights through the haze of smoke and the noise of levee camp labourers, railroad gangs, roustabouts and the like. Of all instrumental jazz styles this is the most folksy and anonymous: even the research of the jazz lovers has failed to turn many of its casually recorded pioneers into more than names, vaguely attached to a location, a blues or two, or a particular pianistic trick ('the chimes', 'the rocks', 'the fives', 'the chains'). There are no masters of the blues piano comparable to the virtuosi of ragtime and its descendants. Many well-known 'boogie-woogie' pianists—Meade Lux Lewis (born 1905), Pete Johnson (born 1904) are limited, while Jimmy Yancey (1898–1951), a most moving player of the blues, is technically downright bad. Some of the forgotten pioneers of the 1920s were probably, within their limitations, better executants, for instance Clarence 'Pinetop' Smith (1904–29), Cripple Clarence Lofton (born c. 1900), and Montana Taylor; so is Albert Ammons (1907–49). As one might expect, blues piano is also by far the most African of jazz piano styles: one might almost say that its tendency is to play the piano as a pure percussion instrument and to concentrate entirely on its rhythmic interest, reducing the melody to endlessly repeated, sometimes very little varied, phrases. Though the blues piano has had considerable influence on the jazz orchestra, notably through the Kansas City tradition, it has not developed much. Like the blues itself, it has remained a substratum of jazz. Until the middle thirties it led a self-contained life in those bar rooms and honky-tonks where it had originated, or in the parlours of Northern immigrant flats, virtually ignored by the main jazz tradition outside Kansas City.

In European art-music drumming is a device to produce incidental effects; in jazz it is the foundation and organizing medium of the entire music, the engine which draws the jazz train along its rails.¹⁵ However, the drum-kit is also a group of instruments in its own right, for, as we have already seen, if every instrument in jazz also has a rhythmic

function, every instrument also has a melodic one. Drums are perhaps the hardest of all jazz instruments for the European-trained listener to appreciate and to analyse. It is often difficult enough for him to train himself actually to listen to them, which is why exhibitionist drum solos are more wildly applauded than they normally ought to be: they are the only drumming that indiscriminating fans can recognize as such.

The evolution of the jazz drum begins with a paradox. Though jazz rhythm is, thanks to its Africanism, far more complex, vital, and important than European rhythm, it was also, to begin with—and still largely is—much cruder and simpler than its African ancestors, thanks to its Europeanism. The history of jazz drumming is the story of its increasing emancipation from the marching military band, with which it started in New Orleans. The old New Orleans drummers, among whom Warren ‘Baby’ Dodds (1898–1959), Zutty Singleton (born 1898), and perhaps Kaiser Marshall (1902–48) are the most eminent, had already turned the heavy march rhythm into a more complex, dancing, jazz rhythm, but their style was still largely determined by its origins. The drums chiefly used are the big bass drum for the main beat, the snare drum for rolls on the weak beats, and the cymbal. Drumming is fairly austere, avoiding solos, except for brief breaks. The accent is on the first and third beat of the four-beat unit, as it is in European music, though the developments of New Orleans music tend to accent the weak beats (two and four).

This development, oddly enough, seems to have come more from the white Dixieland and Chicago players, who also seem to have been the first to develop the exhibitionist, virtuoso aspects of solo drumming (e.g. Gene Krupa of Chicago). For though no instrument shows the inferiority of white players more than the drums—perhaps only Dave Tough (1908–48), the Chicago pioneer, is on a level with the best black drummers—the evolution of black and white drumming seem to have run roughly parallel.

The next great step, and the one most difficult to define or to describe, is the evolution of ‘swing’ drumming, which produces both a more dynamic, and a subtler, more suspended rhythm, and is the foundation of middle period jazz. To say that ‘swing’ accents all four beats evenly, while tending instinctively to lean a little towards the off-beats, does not

help us much. To say that the main drums are liberated from the duty of carrying the main beat, leaving the whole kit free to play much more subtly with the rhythm, is also true, but inadequate. The evolution of the pedal-operated 'high-hat cymbal' which entered jazz around 1928, is very important in this respect: both Jo Jones (born 1911) on the black side (the magnificent drummer of Count Basie's band in its great days), and Dave Tough on the white, were to make this cymbal the main carrier of the beat, giving the rest of their kit a vastly increased scope. However, the great big-band and swing drummers of the 1930s achieved their astonishing combination of rhythmic tension, relaxation, and subtlety with more old-fashioned methods. The chief among them are Chick Webb (1907–39), Cozy Cole (born 1909), Sidney Catlett (1910–51), and Lionel Hampton (born 1913) (who also plays virtually every other rhythmic instrument with extraordinary and instinctive mastery). Oddly enough, some of the most successful big jazz bands, notably Duke Ellington's and Jimmy Lunceford's in the 1930s, created considerable swing while relying on far from sensational drummers; but these were orchestras dominated by jazz arrangers of remarkable talent (Ellington and Sy Oliver, born 1910), who could utilize the rhythmic possibilities of all jazz instruments in combination admirably. (Anyway, even a mediocre black American drummer is normally very good indeed by European standards.)

Swing drumming took the drums to the verge of the revolution achieved by modern jazz, which is the drummers' jazz *par excellence*. It is doubtful whether a technically more brilliant group of drummers has ever existed in jazz than that of Kenny Clarke (born 1914), Max Roach (born 1925), Art Blakey (born 1919), Chico Hamilton (born 1921), and the rest of the modernists.¹⁶ The sort of task the 'modern' drummers set themselves can best be explained in the words of their pioneer Clarke:

I was trying to make the drums more musical instead of just a dead beat.... Around this time I began to play things with the band, with the drums as a real participating instrument with its own voice.... Joe Garland, who played tenor, bass sax, and baritone ... used to write things for me. He'd write out a regular trumpet part for me to read.... He'd just leave it to my own discretion to play the things

out of the part that I thought the most effective. What I mean is, I played rhythm patterns, and they were superimposed over the regular beat.¹⁷

The tendency to make the bass carry the fundamental beat left the drummer increasingly free for such activities. Thus it allowed him to experiment with complex rhythms of the African or Caribbean type, such as were rarely used in jazz. If the reader cares to try to play, or even to recognize when played, four totally different rhythms simultaneously, on hand- and pedal-operated drums, he may get an idea of the rhythmic complexities involved. Some Cuban drummers, notably Chano Pozo (1920–48), were imported into jazz for this purpose around 1948–50, but American drummers themselves adopted some of this complexity thus, paradoxically, producing the most African of all jazz rhythms out of the most urbanized and sophisticated of jazz styles.

The fundamental rhythm of modern jazz continues the evolution from New Orleans to swing: it marks the four beats quite evenly, superimposing stresses on them as occasion requires. It also tends to substitute a fashion of beating the drum legato, to the sharply separate (staccato) beats of traditional drumming.

The remainder of the jazz instruments can be briefly dismissed, since their use has so far not been systematic. The strings have virtually never been used collectively in jazz, though jazz musicians, either for the sake of the schmalz, or the highbrow prestige which they mistakenly believe to attach to string sections, have sometimes had them in the background; always with awful results. It will take some powerful revolutionizing to produce a jazz string orchestra. Solo violins have been used quite a lot, on and off, without ever quite making their mark except in a few (generally white) chamber-type combinations like the Venuti-Lang Blue Four of the late 1920s with Joe Venuti (born 1904), and the Quintet of the Hot Club of France, with Stephane Grapelly (born 1910) and Django Reinhardt (guitar). Stuff Smith (born 1909) and Eddie South (born 1904) are generally considered the best jazz violinists. Modern jazz, as one might expect, has tended to experiment with bowed string sounds, both on the bass and lately on the cello.

A number of other instruments have been used from time to time. The vibraphone (a set of electrified tubular bells) has established itself in the place of the earlier xylophone, and to some extent of the guitar, chiefly due to the dazzling talent of a few players who, for unaccountable reasons, like this sugary instrument, notably Lionel Hampton and Milt Jackson (born 1923).¹⁸ The celesta is occasionally used by pianists, normally to add touches of orchestral colour. The organ has been used by some, notably Fats Waller, but even in his hands produces the same sort of impression as a man trying to write with a shaving brush. Nobody has yet succeeded in producing good jazz on the accordion, but several blues singers have played astonishingly rhythmic and expressive stuff on mouth organs and jews' harps. Modernists have, as usual, been tempted by uncommon wind instruments—flugelhorns (Miles Davis) or flutes (Frank Wess, born 1922)—but the bassoon, Bach trumpet, basset horn, and the rest of the instrumental lunatic fringe still await their jazz discoverers.

There remains the human voice. Though it has been used to incomparable purpose in the blues, nothing is more difficult to discuss than its use in jazz proper. Nobody is really prepared to say what makes a good jazz singer, or what he or she sounds like; or more specifically, what distinguishes jazz singing from jazz-tinged popular singing. Critical evaluation is made all the more difficult because the appeal of the best jazz singers is largely non-musical; in the case of the women, sentimental and sexual. This observer is prepared to say that he knows no male jazz singer worthy of note. Admirable as the gravelly and expressive voice of the great Louis Armstrong is, it seems grotesque to compare his vocal achievement with his wonderful instrumental one. As for women, I am prepared to put my money on Ethel Waters, Billie Holiday, Ella Fitzgerald, and Sarah Vaughan as jazz singers of superb attainments, though the last two slide easily into commercial pop singing in which they excel because of their remarkable sense of rhythm, timbre, and the management of the vocal line. Frankly, however, it would be unwise to base the claims of jazz to great artistic achievement on any jazz singer, with the possible exception of the incomparable Billie Holiday at her best. The blues are another matter. But blues singing, though a very

profound art, is also a very inadaptable one, and the blues singer tackling anything but his or her speciality often makes a sad spectacle.

Notes

- [1.](#) E.g. J. Berendt's diagrams, which are as good as any.
- [2.](#) Sidney Bechet, *Treat It Gentle* (1960); Whitney Balliett, *The Sound of Surprise* (1960), 179–82; C. E. Smith, Pee-Wee Russell in *The Jazz Makers*, Whitney Balliett, 227–32; Nat Shapiro, Benny Goodman in *The Jazz Makers*.
- [3.](#) A. J. McCarthy, *Louis Armstrong*, (1959); Louis Armstrong, *My Life in New Orleans* (1955).
- [4.](#) A. Hodeir, *op. cit.*, Whitney Balliett, 83–5 (Cootie Williams); Whitney Balliett, 103–4 (Red Allen); Nat Hentoff, Roy Eldridge in *The Jazz Makers*; L. Feather, Dizzy Gillespie in *The Jazz Makers*; Michael James, *Ten Modern Jazzmen* for Gillespie, Miles Davis, R. Horricks; *These Jazzmen of Our Time* for Davis; Whitney Balliett, 143–5 (Davis).
- [5.](#) Burnett James, *Bix Beiderbecke* (1959); George Hoefer in *The Jazz Makers*; George Avakian in *The Art of Jazz*. There is an exhaustive chronicle by C. H. Wareing and G. Garlick, *Bugles for Bix* (1958)
- [6.](#) A. Hodeir, *op. cit.* (Wells); Whitney Balliett, 120–2 (Dickenson); J. D. Smith and L. Guttridge, *Jack Teagarden* (1960), also C. E. Smith in *The Jazz Makers*; R. Horricks, *These Jazzmen ...* (J. J. Johnson).
- [7.](#) L. Feather in *The Jazz Makers* (Hawkins, Young); *These Jazzmen ...* (Mulligan, Rollins); *Ten Modern Jazzmen* (Getz, Gray, Mulligan).
- [8.](#) *Ten Modern Jazzmen* (Konitz).
- [9.](#) Max Harrison, *Charlie Parker* (1960); also the same, in Hentoff and McCarthy; Orrin Keepnews in *The Jazz Makers*; *Ten Modern Jazzmen*.
- [10.](#) Berendt, 168.
- [11.](#) L. Feather, *Encyclopedia of Jazz*, 106.
- [12.](#) Bill Simon, Charlie Christian, in *The Jazz Makers*; Al Avakian and George Prince in *The Art of Jazz*.
- [13.](#) Ross Russell in *The Art of Jazz* (James P. Johnson); Charles Fox, *Fats Waller* (1960); John S. Wilson in *The Jazz Makers* (Waller, Hines); Orrin Keepnews, *ibid.* (Art Tatum); *These Jazzmen ...* (Monk, Powell, John Lewis); *Ten Modern Jazzmen* (Monk, Powell).
- [14.](#) Max Harrison in Hentoff and McCarthy, Ernest Borneman in *Just Jazz I* (1957) on boogie-woogie. Blues pianists are mostly discussed in connexion with the history of the blues.
- [15.](#) By far the best description of what jazz drummers do is in Whitney Balliett, especially pp. 159–64, 233–44.
- [16.](#) Nat Hentoff, Warren 'Baby' Dodds in *The Jazz Makers*; Whitney Balliett on Sid Catlett, Max Roach, Art Blakey, Philly Joe Jones.
- [17.](#) *Hear Me Talkin' ...*, 309–310.
- [18.](#) *These Jazzmen ...* (Milt Jackson).

* Among the non-American jazz players of stature we may mention the Frenchmen Combelle and Lafitte (sax), the Dane Kai Winding (trombone), the Swedes Hasselgard and Wickman (clarinet) and Bengt Hallberg (piano), the Belgian Jaspar (sax), the West Indian Dizzy Reece (trumpet), the Britons Bruce Turner, Don Rendell (sax), George Chisholm (trombone), Kenny

Baker (trumpet), and the South African Keipie Moeketsi (clarinet, sax). But there are plenty of others.

* This North-Eastern monopoly of good black jazz pianists is startling. Of the ten pianists listed among the ‘giants of jazz’ in Feather’s *Encyclopedia*, all but three come from this area of the U.S.A.; and the exceptions include the one boogie-woogie pianist in the list, who belongs to a separate category, and Jelly-Roll Morton, who belongs to an earlier historical period.